Earlier this month, the longlist for the International Booker Prize was revealed and, for the first time ever, a Hindi-language novel made the cut—Delhi-based writer Geetanjali Shree's 2019 novel *Ret Samadhi*, translated into English by Daisy Rockwell as *Tomb of Sand*. The Booker nod is well-deserved not only for Shree, but also for Rockwell, who over the past decade or so has quietly built a formidable body of work as a Hindi and Urdu translator. Rockwell (an American who lives in North Bennington, Vermont, US) has now translated works by titans like Bhisham Sahni, Krishna Sobti, Upendranath Ashk, Usha Priyamvada and, recently, the Pakistani writer Khadija Mastur. These translations, immaculate and elegant at the line-by-line level, are also enhanced by Rockwell's vast knowledge of the socio-political histories and regional idiosyncrasies of North India, in particular.

During a recent interview over Zoom, Rockwell shared with us the beginnings of her journey as a translator, as a graduate student at the University of Chicago in the early 1990s. "It had gotten to the stage where I was pretty good at Hindi," she says. "But I wasn't able to make the leap into reading full-length books. A couple of my professors helped—Colin Masica, who was a linguist and my advisor—and the Indian writer A.K. Ramanujan. Masica assigned me a 1,000-page book, Yashpal's Partition novel *Jhootha Sach*, to begin with!"

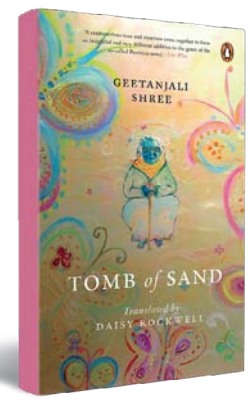
Having been thrown into the deep end, so to speak, Rockwell went about reading widely about the Indian subcontinent in the pre-Partition era—texts on the geography, the economics, even non-fiction that described the markets, the businesses, the food, the clothes and so on. "By the time I started reading Ashk," Rockwell recalls, "I already felt like I knew Lahore so well." Rockwell eventually met Ashk in India and persuaded him to let her translate his works, in particular his epic novel cycle *Girti Deewarein*; the first two novels in the cycle are now available in English as *Falling Walls* and *In the City a Mirror Wandering*, respectively.

"A.K. Ramanujan said, during a seminar, that for the translator, every footnote was a confession of failure," Rockwell says. "He had this way of speaking wherein almost every sentence that came out of his mouth sounded like an aphorism; you would never forget it. But also, he was talking about translating poetry when he said this. For longer works, he thought that you could teach the reader how to read the book as it went along, and you can see this in motion in some of the great Russian novels."

Rockwell implements this advice admirably in *Ret Samadhi/ Tomb of Sand*, a novel that follows its protagonist, a recently widowed, nearly 80-year-old woman as she gains a new lease of life, prompting her to retrace her youth which was spent in what is now Pakistan. Themes and metaphors of death and reincarnation are used liberally throughout. 'Tomb', in that vein, is just one of the meanings that the Hindi word '*samadhi*' can convey—it can also mean 'shrine' or an act of self-immolation, typically undertaken by a sage. Rockwell spells out the various meanings just before Page 1, uses 'tomb' and other, narrower English words for '*samadhi*' towards the beginning and by the end, when the reader has stuck around to understand the concept, uses just '*samadhi*' without further explanation.

Tomb of Sand's formal audacity also comes to the fore in a passage deep into the second half, where several well-known authors of Partition novels—and some of their characters—make cameo appearances in a chapter that resembles a David Lynch fever dream. When Rockwell first decided to translate the novel, she thought since the narrative was set in contemporary times, it would be a break from her work translating Partition classics such as Bhisham Sahni's *Tamas* and Krishna Sobti's *Gujarat Pakistan Se Gujarat Hindustan*. The scene came as a bit of a pleasant surprise, then.

"As a translator, it made me feel smug because I had translated some of those



TOMB OF SAND
by Geetanjali Shree; translated by Daisy Rockwell
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PARTITION LITERATURE HAS BEEN A RECURRING THEME IN DAISY ROCKWELL'S TRANSLATIONS. SHE HAS EVEN WRITTEN SCHOLARLY WORKS ON IT